

**The Commodification of Women In Nigerian Popular Music:
A Critical Look At Davido's "Na Money"**

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Abstract

Nigerian music production and scripting have significantly evolved, gaining global recognition as seen by the numerous awards secured by Nigerian artists, including the esteemed Grammy and BET awards. Nevertheless, the genre continues to address various social issues, particularly gender representation, with a strong focus on females. These themes are evident in the lyrics, subject matter, and music videos. This study explores gender issues, specifically the commodification of women in Nigerian music, using Davido's "Na Money" as a case study. Employing qualitative methodologies and content analysis, the research assessed both the musical and visual elements of the song. The findings reveal that Nigerian music, as a facet of popular culture, often depicts women as commodities subject to purchase and influenced by wealth. This portrayal reflects societal realities in Nigeria. Moreover, the genre fails to address the dangers associated with the commodification of women. It is recommended that Nigerian popular music, as a medium of influence, should promote a new ideology encouraging women to recognize the risks of commodification, which often leads to various forms of abuse and other dangers.

Keywords: Commodification, Nigerian Popular Music, Women Objectification



Title: Davido's "Na Money"

Introduction

Nigerian popular music, especially in genres like Afrobeats, hip-hop, and highlife, has achieved global acclaim. However, it faces criticism for how it depicts gender roles, particularly through the objectification and commodification of women. These musical styles, whether traditional, contemporary, or artistic, often explore themes such as love, sadness, wealth, religion, and social commentary. Davido's "Na Money" highlights the influence of wealth on society and interpersonal relationships. While the song underscores the significance of wealth, it also treats women as commodities that can be exchanged for financial gain. This portrayal suggests that women are seen as individuals who can be bought, reinforcing harmful stereotypes that imply their primary attraction to men is financial.

Consequently, it is essential to critically analyze these gender stereotypes that have increasingly appeared in Nigerian popular music, to explore the broader societal implications of such representations of women in Nigeria, and to evaluate how audiences interpret the song's messages regarding gender and commodification. Employing qualitative methods, particularly textual analysis, the study highlights that Nigerian music often reflects and shapes societal attitudes toward various issues. Women in traditional Nigerian societies have essential roles in family, politics, economy, social life, spirituality, and cultural preservation.

While one might argue that the song misrepresents women as mere commodities, the analysis also reveals moral lessons, particularly encouraging individuals to strive for wealth. Women can learn from this negative narrative; to avoid being depicted as commodities, they should pursue financial independence. Thus, Nigerian popular music can have various interpretations due to its philosophical depth, which invites critical analysis of its themes.

This paper focuses on gender issues in Nigerian popular music, examining the representation of women and the implications of these portrayals. Popular music serves not just as entertainment but as a powerful influence in shaping cultural norms, societal views, and individual values

related to gender and relationships. The widespread global reach of these messages ensures that their underlying narratives are ingrained in the consciousness of diverse audiences, shaping behaviors and attitudes. This pervasive impact highlights the necessity of examining the narratives promoted within these songs. The reduction of women to marketable objects valued for their physical appearance or sexual appeal undermines their full humanity and inherent worth, reducing complex individuals to mere commodities often for commercial purposes.

At the forefront of the global music scene, particularly within the vibrant Afrobeats genre, stands Davido, an artist of immense cultural influence across Africa and beyond. His prominence makes his artistic output a significant barometer of prevailing cultural dynamics. His song "*Na Money*," featured on his 2023 album "*Timeless*", offers a timely and highly relevant case study for exploring these themes within the context of modern popular music.

Through a critical analysis of its lyrical content and a careful contextualization within broader trends in popular and Nigerian music, this expose argues that Davido's "*Na Money*" distinctly exemplifies the commodification of women. The song perpetuates a transactional view of relationships where female value is intrinsically linked to male financial provision, subtly embedding this ideology into the collective consciousness. When influential music consistently portrays relationships in this manner, where a man's financial investment is presented as the primary driver for a woman's affection, presence, or compliance, it reinforces a specific, and potentially harmful, economic model for interpersonal connections. The repeated exposure to such narratives can lead audiences, particularly younger demographics, to perceive these dynamics as natural or even desirable. This normalization can, in turn, manifest in real-world behavioural changes, influencing dating patterns, diminishing a woman's sense of self-worth by tying it to material acquisition, and fostering unrealistic expectations in romantic partnerships, ultimately impacting the health and equity of relationships.

Although existing scholarship on gender representation in popular music has extensively examined themes of sexualization, objectification, and patriarchal dominance, much of this literature remains generalized, Western-centric, or focused on music videos and global pop industries, with limited sustained attention to lyrical narratives within contemporary Nigerian Afrobeats. Studies addressing Nigerian popular music often discuss misogyny or female stereotyping in broad terms but rarely undertake close textual and discourse-based analysis of individual songs that have achieved mass cultural influence.

Research Problem

The central research problem this study addresses is the insufficient scholarly interrogation of how commodification of women is linguistically constructed and normalized through lyrics in mainstream Nigerian popular music, particularly in songs that explicitly equate women's value with economic exchange. While previous studies acknowledge the presence of objectification, they tend to treat it as a background cultural phenomenon rather than examining how specific lyrical choices, metaphors, and narratives actively reproduce capitalist and patriarchal ideologies.

In the case of Davido's *Na Money*, women are repeatedly framed as transactional entities whose desirability and worth are determined by male economic power. However, existing literature has

not sufficiently explored how such representations function as cultural texts that reinforce gendered power relations, nor how they resonate within Nigeria's socio-economic context, where wealth, masculinity, and social status are deeply intertwined. This gap leaves unresolved questions about how popular music contributes to the normalization of gender inequality and the commodification of female identity in everyday cultural consumption.

METHODOLOGY

Research Design

This study adopts a qualitative textual analysis research design to examine the commodification of women in Nigerian popular music, with specific focus on Davido's *Na Money*. Qualitative textual analysis is appropriate for this study because it allows for an in-depth interpretation of meanings embedded in cultural texts, particularly song lyrics, which function as vehicles for ideological expression. Rather than seeking statistical generalization, this approach prioritizes contextual understanding, interpretive depth, and theoretical insight into how language constructs social reality.

The song *Na Money* is treated as a cultural text whose lyrics both reflect and shape dominant discourses surrounding gender, wealth, and power within contemporary Nigerian society. Specifically, the song was analyzed to uncover recurring themes around commodification and sexual objectification of women.

Data Source and Selection Criteria

The primary data for this study consist of the official lyrics of Davido's *Na Money*, as released through authorized music platforms. The song was purposively selected based on three criteria. First, it achieved significant commercial success and wide circulation, making it culturally influential. Second, the song explicitly foregrounds money as a central theme, linking economic power to attraction and desire. Third, its lyrical content provides a clear basis for examining the intersection of gender representation, capitalism, and patriarchy.

Secondary data include peer-reviewed journal articles, books, and scholarly commentaries on gender, popular music, objectification, and Nigerian cultural studies. These sources are used to contextualize the analysis and support theoretical interpretation.

THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

This study is anchored in an interdisciplinary theoretical framework that draws on feminist theory, objectification theory, and cultural materialism to examine the commodification of women in Nigerian popular music. These theoretical perspectives provide the conceptual tools necessary to interrogate how gender, power, and economic ideology intersect within the lyrical construction of women in Davido's *Na Money*. By foregrounding language as a site of ideological production, the framework enables a critical reading of popular music as a cultural text that both reflects and reinforces patriarchal capitalist values.

Feminist Theory and Gender Representation

Feminist theory provides the primary lens through which this study examines gendered power relations in popular music. Feminist scholars argue that patriarchal societies systematically construct women as subordinate to men through cultural practices, representations, and

discourses that normalize inequality (de Beauvoir). Within media and cultural texts, women are frequently represented as passive objects of male desire rather than as autonomous subjects with agency (hooks).

Applied to popular music, feminist theory reveals how lyrical narratives often privilege male perspectives while marginalizing or silencing female voices. Songs that center male economic power and sexual entitlement reproduce what hooks describes as the normalization of domination, presenting gender inequality as natural and desirable. In the context of Nigerian popular music, feminist theory is particularly useful for unpacking how traditional gender norms intersect with contemporary capitalist aspirations, producing representations of women that align femininity with dependence, desirability, and exchange value.

Through this lens, *Na Money* is examined as a cultural narrative that reinforces patriarchal assumptions by equating female attraction and worth with male financial capacity. Feminist theory thus enables the study to critique not only what is represented, but also whose interests these representations serve.

Objectification Theory

Objectification theory, developed by Fredrickson and Roberts, provides a framework for understanding how women's bodies and identities are reduced to objects for consumption. According to this theory, objectification occurs when a person is treated primarily as a thing rather than a full human subject, valued for usefulness, appearance, or sexual appeal. In popular music, objectification is often embedded in lyrical and metaphorical language that fragments women into desirable attributes.

In this study, objectification theory is extended to examine commodification, where women are not only objectified but also framed as economic entities whose value is determined by monetary exchange. Lyrics that associate women with luxury items, rewards, or financial success exemplify this process. Such representations deny women subjectivity by positioning them as outcomes of male consumption rather than participants in mutual relationships.

Objectification theory allows the study to systematically analyze how *Na Money* constructs women through economic metaphors that strip them of agency and reframe desire as transaction. It also helps to explain how repeated exposure to such narratives contributes to the normalization of sexist ideologies in everyday cultural life.

Cultural Materialism and Capitalist Ideology

Cultural materialism provides a broader socio-economic context for interpreting gender representation in popular music. Rooted in Marxist theory, cultural materialism emphasizes the role of material conditions, economic systems, and power structures in shaping cultural production (Williams). From this perspective, popular music is not ideologically neutral but is deeply embedded in capitalist relations that prioritize wealth, consumption, and profit.

In Nigerian popular music, displays of affluence and financial success are central narrative devices that reflect broader socio-economic realities, including inequality, unemployment, and the symbolic power of wealth. Cultural materialism helps explain why money becomes a dominant theme in Afrobeats and how it functions as a marker of masculine identity and social

legitimacy.

By applying cultural materialism, this study situates *Na Money* within a capitalist cultural economy where women are symbolically positioned as commodities that validate male success. This framework reveals how the commodification of women in popular music is not merely an artistic choice but a reflection of structural economic ideologies that shape gender relations.

Integrating the Frameworks

The integration of feminist theory, objectification theory, and cultural materialism allows for a multidimensional analysis of *Na Money*. Feminist theory exposes the gendered power relations at play; objectification theory clarifies the mechanisms through which women are reduced to objects and commodities; and cultural materialism situates these representations within Nigeria's socio-economic and capitalist context.

Together, these frameworks enable the study to move beyond descriptive critique and offer a theoretically grounded analysis of how popular music functions as an ideological apparatus. The framework thus supports the central argument that the commodification of women in Nigerian popular music is a product of intersecting patriarchal and capitalist forces that are reproduced and legitimized through lyrical discourse.

Research Focus

This study therefore focuses on:

- i. A critical textual and feminist analysis of *Na Money* as a cultural artifact;
- ii. The ways in which capitalist discourse and patriarchy intersect in the song's lyrical construction of women;
- iii. How repeated exposure to such narratives in popular music shapes social perceptions of gender, value, and agency in Nigerian society.

By foregrounding lyrics rather than visuals alone, the study shifts analytical attention to language as a primary vehicle of ideological transmission in popular music.

Scholarly Contribution

The study makes three key scholarly contributions:

- i. Context-Specific Analysis: It contributes to African popular music studies by providing a Nigeria-centered, song-specific analysis, moving beyond generalized critiques of misogyny to examine how commodification operates within Afrobeats lyrics.
- ii. Theoretical Integration: By drawing on feminist theory, objectification theory, and cultural materialism, the study demonstrates how popular music functions as a site where gender ideology and capitalist values converge, offering a nuanced framework for analyzing similar texts.
- iii. Expansion of Gender and Music Scholarship: The study extends existing feminist music criticism by highlighting how economic metaphors in Nigerian popular music redefine femininity in transactional terms, thus contributing to broader debates on media influence, gender socialization, and cultural power in postcolonial societies.

Gap Statement

While existing studies have examined the objectification of women in global and Nigerian

popular music, limited attention has been paid to the lyrical mechanisms through which commodification is articulated and normalized in contemporary Afrobeats. Moreover, there is a paucity of research that situates these representations within Nigeria's socio-economic realities and examines individual songs as influential cultural texts. This study addresses this gap by offering a feminist textual analysis of Davido's *Na Money*, exposing how economic discourse in popular music reinforces gendered power relations and the commodification of women.

REVIEW OF RELATED LITERATURE

Gender Representation in Popular Music

Scholarly engagement with popular music has long recognized it as a powerful cultural medium that reflects and shapes social values, identities, and power relations. Feminist scholars argue that popular music functions not merely as entertainment but as a site of ideological production where gender norms are constructed and circulated (Frith and McRobbie 375). Across global music industries, women are frequently represented through narratives that emphasize physical appearance, sexual availability, and emotional dependency, often reinforcing patriarchal hierarchies.

Research within Western pop, hip-hop, and rap traditions demonstrates how women are positioned as objects of male desire and consumption, while men are framed as active subjects endowed with agency, control, and economic power (Railton and Watson 2011). These representations contribute to the normalization of gender inequality by embedding sexist assumptions into everyday cultural consumption. However, while these studies offer valuable insights, they often prioritize visual aesthetics and performance over lyrical discourse, leaving a critical gap in understanding how language itself encodes gender ideology.

Objectification and Sexualization of Women in Lyrics and Videos



Naira Marley's Puta

Objectification theory, as articulated by Fredrickson and Roberts, explains how women's bodies are treated as objects valued primarily for their use or consumption by others (Calogero 574). Within popular music, this objectification frequently extends into commodification, where women are metaphorically constructed as goods that can be acquired, displayed, or exchanged. Marxist feminist scholars argue that commodification is inseparable from capitalist logic, which reduces human value to market worth (Hudson and Michael 442).

In music lyrics, commodification often manifests through metaphors of purchase, luxury, and ownership, framing romantic or sexual relationships as economic transactions. Women are depicted as rewards for male financial success, thereby reinforcing the idea that male wealth legitimizes dominance and access to female bodies. Although global scholarship has extensively documented these trends, the majority of such studies focus on Western music cultures, with limited attention to how commodification operates within African popular music contexts, particularly at the level of lyrical narrative.

David's *Na Money* is more than just an Afrobeats anthem; it explores wealth as a symbol of power, success, and desirability. The song, like many Nigerian tracks, intertwines financial prosperity with depictions of women, reinforcing materialistic values. Nigerian music often portrays relationships as transactional, where women receive gifts or money in exchange for companionship or sexual pleasure. Songs like *Dumebi* by Rema and *If* by David exemplify this trend, emphasizing the perception of women's worth based on material gain from men.

As far back as Fela's music videos, women clad in scant dresses had been featured, lending premise to the fact that women are gaze objects from which men can derive pleasure. In Iyanya's music video "Flavor", He compares a woman to an orange and, of course, oranges are to be eaten and thrown away. Even more recent is Naira Marley's *Put*, a veritable example of how the woman's body is, so to say, dismembered, with the camera focusing on the sensitive parts, gratifying the sexual desires of men and by extension, the audience.

This portrayal contributes to a culture of objectification, where women in music videos and lyrics are often reduced to their physical appeal. Such representations have harmful effects on women's self-esteem and mental health, as repeated exposure to sexualized imagery normalizes their devaluation. This contributes to gendered power imbalances, making it harder for women to be seen beyond their sexual or material worth.

Moreover, economic and artistic pressures push artists toward provocative themes that guarantee attention and commercial success, even at the cost of perpetuating stereotypes. This trend dehumanizes women by framing them as mere objects of desire.

African and Nigerian Popular Music Scholarship

African popular music scholarship has increasingly examined how music intersects with identity, politics, and social change. Nigerian popular music, especially Afrobeats, has been recognized as a dominant cultural force both locally and globally. Scholars note that Afrobeats often celebrates themes of wealth, success, masculinity, and pleasure, reflecting broader socio-economic aspirations in postcolonial Nigerian society (Ugor 132).

Studies addressing gender in Nigerian music frequently highlight misogynistic lyrics,

hypermasculinity, and the marginalization of women's voices. Researchers such as Omoniyi and Afolayan argue that women in Nigerian popular music are often portrayed as accessories to male success, valued for beauty and sexual appeal rather than autonomy or intellect. However, much of this scholarship adopts a broad thematic approach, critiquing misogyny as a general phenomenon without engaging in close textual analysis of specific songs that enjoy widespread cultural circulation.

Moreover, existing literature often conflates objectification with commodification, without sufficiently interrogating how economic language and capitalist imagery actively structure gender relations within lyrics. This oversight limits scholarly understanding of how popular music not only reflects sexism but actively participates in constructing transactional notions of femininity.

Capitalism, Masculinity, and Cultural Power



Masculinity in popular music is frequently articulated through displays of economic dominance, material wealth, and consumption. Connell's theory of hegemonic masculinity provides a useful framework for understanding how male power is legitimized through cultural practices, including music. In Nigerian popular music, financial success is often portrayed as the ultimate marker of masculine achievement, granting men authority, respect, and sexual access.

This alignment of masculinity with wealth has significant implications for gender representation. When male economic power becomes the central narrative, women are positioned as beneficiaries, dependents, or commodities within male success stories. Feminist cultural theorists argue that such narratives reinforce patriarchal capitalism by naturalizing unequal gender relations and presenting them as aspirational or normative (hooks).

Despite the prevalence of these themes, few studies have critically examined how specific lyrical constructions link money, masculinity, and female value in Nigerian popular music. This gap is particularly evident in analyses of commercially successful Afrobeats songs that reach diverse audiences and shape popular consciousness.

Commodifying Narrative/Stereotype

Musical lyrics and, by extension, music videos construct narratives about women that not only sexualize them but also reduce their worth to how much money men are willing to part with. The commodification and objectification of women have led these musical productions to portray women in ways that reinforce stereotypes within popular culture, particularly as musicians have become influential shapers of cultural values. These narratives and stereotypes are outlined below:

Focus on Physical Appearance/Sexual Appeal

Musical lyrics and music videos of popular Nigerian music predominantly emphasis on women's bodies, often barely clothed, with erotic gestures and provocative dancing. They are engage in visual fragmentation of bodies (e.g., focus on buttocks), as they sexualize these body parts and sing about how desirable and how the woman offer to them these sexual parts of their bodies in exchange for money. The music videos are replete with barely clad women, exposing sensitive parts of their body. This reduces women to visual objects for male consumption, emphasizing external appearance over holistic identity and intellect.

Women as Materialistic/Transactional

Popular Nigerian musical lyrics and music video portray women as people whose affection or presence can be "bought with money" or are available to the highest bidder, with love dependent on financial expenditure. Women are constantly portrayed in obscene manner both in the lyrics and images; lyrics often portray women as materialistic, suggesting they can be bought with money. The music link female worth, affection, and availability directly to financial gain, fostering a transactional view of relationships and undermining genuine connection.

Women as Objects of Pleasure/Sex Toys

Lyrics that reduce women to their sexual utility, implying they exist primarily for male gratification. Women are frequently reduced to 'mere objects of pleasure' or 'sex toys.' Dehumanizes women, denies their autonomy, and promotes their use as instruments for male sexual gratification, disregarding their personhood.

Emphasis on Specific Body Parts



Hyper-focus on particular anatomical features, such as buttocks, often reducing a woman's entire personality to these attributes. References to "booty bounce" and buttocks as "load", leads to visual fragmentation and reduction of women to anatomical features, further reinforcing their objectification and diminishing their identity.

Consented Objectification

Consented objectification refers to situations where women appear to willingly participate in sexualized representations of their bodies as a perceived route to visibility, success, or economic gain in the music industry. While framed as choice and agency, such participation often occurs within patriarchal industry structures that reward sexualized femininity, thereby complicating the notion of truly free consent.

1. **Performative Sexual Self-Objectification:** Female performers intentionally present their bodies as objects of desire through lyrics, dance, fashion, and visuals. This form of objectification is consented because women actively participate in shaping these portrayals. However, while it may be interpreted as empowerment and self-expression, it simultaneously reinforces commodification within a male-dominated cultural economy.
2. **Economic or Transactional Objectification:** In this form, women willingly commodify their sexuality or beauty in exchange for material benefits such as money, luxury, or elevated social status. Popular Nigerian music often frames this dynamic as a mutually beneficial exchange, masking deeper power imbalances and normalizing the reduction of female value to economic desirability.
3. **Visual Objectification by Professional Models and Video Vixens:** Women who work as dancers, models, or video vixens knowingly consent to eroticized visual representation as part of their professional labour. Though their bodies are often

fragmented to satisfy the male gaze, consent is rooted in contractual agreements, financial compensation, and career aspirations within the entertainment industry.

4. **Lyrical Self-Identification as Sexual Objects:** Some women in Nigerian pop music adopt sexually explicit or objectifying language to describe themselves, emphasizing desirability, physical attributes, or sexual confidence. Here, consent is expressed through self-labeling rather than external imposition, aligning with global pop and hip-hop aesthetics that valorize sexual openness.
5. **Social Media–Driven Objectification Linked to Music Promotion:** Female artists and influencers increasingly rely on hyper-sexualized self-presentation on social media to promote music and maintain relevance. While participation is voluntary, platform algorithms and audience expectations incentivize sexualized visibility, blurring the line between strategic self-branding and objectification.
6. **Narrative Objectification Framed as Enjoyment or Pleasure:** Music videos often depict women as enjoying male desire and attention, emphasizing pleasure to signal consent. This framing normalizes objectification by presenting it as glamorous and empowering, while subtly reinforcing gender hierarchies that define women's value through male approval.

Consented objectification in Nigerian popular music embodies a paradox of agency and constraint. Although women appear to choose participation in sexualized representation, these choices are shaped by patriarchal, capitalist, and global cultural systems that reward sexual display. Consent, therefore, complicates rather than eliminates concerns about power imbalance, exploitation, and gendered representation.

Commodification of Women in Davido's *Na Money*

Davido's "*Na Money*," a track from his 2023 album "Timeless," provides a compelling contemporary example of the commodification of women within popular music. A detailed analysis of its fragmented lyrics reveals a consistent thematic emphasis on wealth as the primary driver of romantic and interpersonal dynamics.

The core theme permeating "*Na Money*" is the explicit linkage of money to a woman's value and the dynamics of a relationship. The repeated phrase, "there's money on the job money", immediately establishes finance as the central currency of the interaction. This notion is further reinforced by lines such as "I bring money I go say there's money on the job money", and the explicit promise, "If I got that money I could give you all you want". These lines collectively position financial provision as the fundamental prerequisite for a successful or desired interaction with the woman.

The song's lyrics feature clear transactional offers and expectations. The artist explicitly offers material wealth and luxury goods, stating, "Give am Gucci, Prada, give am Fendi and Dior, Give her everything cause she deserve it and more". This lavish provision is presented as a direct exchange for the woman's presence, compliance, or affection. This is implied by phrases like "shy say she go roll me if I go" and "shorty say she go if I go", suggesting that her willingness to engage or accompany him is contingent upon his financial capabilities. The phrase "give her everything cuz she deserve it" subtly implies that her "deserving" is not an inherent quality but

rather contingent upon her acceptance of his financial provisions and her role within this transactional dynamic.

Furthermore, the song subtly presents physical appearance as a commodity. The line "why you fine like you go if you look" powerfully links the woman's physical attractiveness ("fine") to her potential for being acquired or influenced ("you go if you look"). Her beauty is implicitly presented not just as an aesthetic quality but as an asset that activates the male's desire to provide money, effectively transforming her physical appearance into a functional asset within the exchange.

The explicit linkage of money to a woman's presence and the offering of luxury goods in exchange for her compliance ("she go roll me if I go") directly illustrates the commodification of her body and presence. She is reduced to an object whose value and availability are determined by the financial investment made by the male artist. The emphasis on "everything" she "deserves" being material possessions ("Gucci, Prada, Fendi, Dior") reduces her needs and desires to consumer goods, further reinforcing her status as a recipient of material provision rather than an autonomous individual with diverse needs and aspirations. This is a clear instance of her sexuality and potentially her morality being commodified. Her availability, loyalty, or "good behavior" are implicitly tied to the financial "upkeep" provided. The line "why you fine like you go if you look" objectifies the woman by focusing on her physical appearance as the primary trigger for the male's transactional offers. Her "finess" is not appreciated for its inherent aesthetic value but for its potential to elicit a financially driven response, turning her beauty into a functional asset within the exchange.

Dangers Associated with Commodification and Objectification of Women

The commodification and objectification of women in Nigerian popular music pose several dangers that can affect societal perceptions, individual self-worth, and interpersonal relationships. Some of the key dangers associated with these issues are:

- a) **Perpetuation of Harmful Stereotypes:** according to Uzoechi, the portrayal of women as commodities often reinforces harmful stereotypes that suggest women's value is primarily based on their physical appearance or sexual appeal (55). This undermines their complexity and contributions to society.
- b) **Impact on Self-Perception:** Akinwumi highlights that women exposed to these portrayals may internalize the notion that their worth is tied to their appearance or sexual availability, leading to low self-esteem and body image issues (12).
- c) **Normalization of Violence and Abuse:** In Adebayo's opinion, the sexual imagery and objectification often depicted in music can desensitize listeners to violence against women, normalizing harmful behaviors and attitudes (329).
- d) **Societal Acceptance of Gender Inequality:** The commodification of women through music can contribute to broader societal acceptance of gender inequality, as these narratives reinforce the idea that women are lesser than men (Eze 45).
- e) **Impact on Relationships:** Chukwuma highlights that the notion that financial wealth is a primary motivator for women's attraction to men can hinder genuine emotional connections, reducing relationships to transactional arrangements (167).
- f) **Call to Action for Change:** in Okafor's view, addressing the dangers of commodification in music requires a cultural shift, encouraging the portrayal of women

as powerful agents with agency rather than as objects for consumption (403).

Parallels with Davido's Other Works (e.g., "IF")

The themes explored in "*Na Money*" are not isolated but reflect a consistent pattern within Davido's broader discography. A previous academic analysis of his song "*IF*" found that he portrays love as "dependent on the amount of money a man is able to spend on a woman". This study explicitly states that Davido "presents physical appearance as the greatest asset of a woman which is meant for the highest bidder" and "objectifies the body of women while highlighting finance as the only basis for a woman to respond positively to a man's romantic advances".

Lyrical expressions from "*IF*," such as "My money my body na your own" and "Thirty billion for the account, io / Versace and Gucci for your body, o baby", bear striking thematic and even specific luxury brand similarities to the themes and references found in "*Na Money*". This strong congruence demonstrates a consistent ideological pattern across Davido's discography, reinforcing the notion that his artistic persona frequently intertwines concepts of love, romance, and female value with financial provision and material acquisition.

The consistent lyrical themes observed across multiple songs by Davido, such as "*IF*" and "*Na Money*", which repeatedly link financial wealth to love, physical appearance, and female compliance, suggest more than just isolated instances of commodification. This recurring pattern indicates the propagation of a broader, deeply ingrained patriarchal economic ideology through his highly influential music. This ideology positions the male as the primary provider and controller of wealth within a relationship, and the female as the recipient whose value, affection, and responsiveness are directly tied to this provision. This framework reinforces traditional gender roles where women's economic agency is minimized, and their worth is externally validated through material possessions and the financial "upkeep" provided by a man. This consistent messaging from a highly influential artist can significantly solidify and normalize these patriarchal economic dynamics in the minds of listeners, particularly in societies where such traditional gender roles might already be prevalent. It can subtly discourage female economic independence, foster a sense of entitlement in men, and reinforce male dominance through financial leverage in interpersonal and romantic relationships.

In contemporary Nigerian society, there is a growing acceptance of musical narratives where "greater attention is paid to money and physical attractiveness as essential determinants of love" (Chinasa, Nnanyelugo, Onu, and Onwuegbuna (39). This suggests a concerning societal shift away from traditional values like hard work, family history, and good conduct in determining romantic relations, towards a predominant focus on money and physical appearance (Chinasa, Nnanyelugo, Samson Onu & Ikenna Onwuegbuna (40). The constant bombardment of images dictating "who they should be, what they need to look like, and how they are expected to balance their lives" creates immense psychological and social pressure on women.

The commodification of women's bodies, sexuality, morality, and feelings can lead to a profound devaluation of women's human characteristics, compromising their health, physical integrity, and overall well-being (Barbosa, A. Dos Santos, Mercello Romani-Dias & Tania Modesto Veludo-de-Oliveira, 583). It can create an environment that implicitly or explicitly

condones violation and violence, as exemplified by instances of forced sexual acts and physical abuse when perceived "ownership" is challenged. The prevalence of such themes in popular music contributes to a cultural milieu where misogynistic beliefs and attitudes are normalized and perpetuated.

The research indicates a complex, self-perpetuating cycle where music content often reflects "what consumers want". If audiences consistently consume, celebrate, and financially support music that commodifies women, it sends a clear signal to artists and producers that this type of content is commercially viable and desired. This, in turn, incentivizes the creation and promotion of more such music, thereby reinforcing existing biases and hindering the emergence of more equitable and empowering portrayals. The "growing acceptance" of these commodifying narratives in society fuels the demand, which in turn fuels the supply from the music industry, creating a vicious cycle that is difficult to break without multi-faceted intervention. Effectively addressing the commodification of women in popular music requires not only critiquing the artists and the music industry but also fostering critical media literacy and conscious consumption among audiences. Breaking this cycle necessitates a shift in consumer preferences and a collective refusal to support content that perpetuates harmful stereotypes. This implies a shared responsibility across the entire ecosystem of cultural production and consumption.

Gaps in Existing Literature

While existing scholarship acknowledges the objectification of women in popular music, several gaps remain evident. First, there is a lack of song-specific, lyric-centered analyses within Nigerian popular music studies. Second, there is insufficient engagement with commodification as a distinct analytical category, separate from general objectification. Third, few studies situate these representations within Nigeria's socio-economic realities, where economic precarity and wealth display play central roles in social status and gender relations.

Most importantly, there is limited scholarly attention to how popular Nigerian music normalizes transactional relationships through repeated exposure to economic metaphors that equate female worth with male financial capacity. This gap necessitates a focused examination of individual songs as cultural texts capable of reinforcing ideological norms.

Positioning the Present Study

This study addresses these gaps by offering a feminist textual analysis of Davido's "*Na Money*", a song that explicitly foregrounds wealth as the basis for attraction, desire, and female validation. By examining the song's lyrics as a cultural narrative, the study exposes how commodification operates linguistically to construct women as economic objects within a patriarchal capitalist framework.

In doing so, the research contributes to gender and music scholarship by shifting analytical attention from generalized critique to context-specific, lyric-driven analysis, thereby deepening understanding of how Nigerian popular music participates in the reproduction of gender inequality. The study ultimately positions popular music as a powerful ideological site where gender, capitalism, and cultural power intersect.

Summary of Findings

"*Na Money*" by Davido is a vibrant celebration of wealth, success, and the joys that come with financial freedom. The central theme revolves around how money enables a luxurious lifestyle, garners admiration, and elevates social status. Through proud and joyful lyrics, Davido conveys the confidence that comes from success, while subtly addressing the judgment and envy faced by those who thrive financially. The song champions a mindset of abundance and underscores the societal power and respect that money commands, particularly in relationships and public perception.

Culturally, the song is rooted in African identity, blending Nigerian Pidgin English with proverbs and traditional expressions that make it relatable and authentic. The inclusion of The Cavemen, who bring a highlife flavor, and Angélique Kidjo, a globally respected Beninese artist, gives the track a Pan-African richness. This collaboration bridges generational and regional musical styles, reflecting a unity and celebration of African heritage through both language and sound.

Musically, "*Na Money*" fuses Afrobeats with highlife and traditional African elements, featuring live instrumentation that enhances its celebratory and classic vibe. The production is layered and smooth, creating a joyful atmosphere that complements the lyrical message. This song stands as more than just a dance track – it's a proud statement of African excellence and Davido's artistic ability to merge modern and traditional influences while promoting a powerful image of success and cultural pride.

The visual representation in "*Na Money*" is more than just a backdrop for the music – it is an integral part of the storytelling. By blending luxurious visuals with dynamic editing and culturally resonant imagery, Davido crafts a visual narrative that celebrates success, reflects modern African urbanity, and invites the audience into a world where money and style are intimately linked.

As such, the song acts as both a mirror and a mold of societal values, resonating deeply with a generation that is striving to reconcile traditional cultural narratives with the realities of a global, modern economy.

Recommendation and Conclusion

To further consolidate and expand the success of "*Na Money*," Davido could strategically pursue additional cross-generational collaborations that foreground Africa's rich musical diversity, building on the intergenerational synergy already evident in the track. Complementing the song with a high-quality visual production that thoughtfully integrates themes of African cultural identity and contemporary luxury would significantly enhance its symbolic and commercial value, while broadening its transnational appeal. Furthermore, sustained promotion through carefully curated live performances and deliberate social media engagement would help maintain audience interest, reinforce cultural relevance, and firmly position "*Na Money*" as a defining work within Davido's evolving discography.

Davido's "*Na Money*" is a vibrant celebration of wealth, success, and high living, featuring contributions from Angélique Kidjo and The Cavemen. The track blends Afrobeats with

highlife and elements of traditional African instrumentation, creating a rich and dynamic sonic experience. Lyrically, it portrays a confident embrace of affluence and status, aligning with the themes often present in Davido's music. The collaboration with legendary artists adds depth and authenticity, bridging generational and stylistic gaps while reinforcing Davido's global appeal.

It is recommended that Nigerian popular music, given its powerful role in shaping social values and cultural consciousness, should actively promote a new ideology that empowers women to critically recognize and resist the risks of commodification. When women's bodies and identities are repeatedly portrayed as marketable assets for visual pleasure or commercial gain, such representations can normalize objectification and reinforce harmful gender hierarchies, often exposing women to exploitation, abuse, and psychological harm. By advancing narratives that foreground women's autonomy, intellect, creativity, and agency rather than their sexualized value, popular music can serve as a tool for awareness and transformation. This ideological shift would not only encourage female artists and audiences to question exploitative industry norms but also challenge producers, directors, and consumers to adopt more ethical forms of representation, thereby contributing to a safer cultural environment that affirms women's dignity and reduces their vulnerability to abuse and other associated dangers.

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